Sonay Kartal's Comeback Rolls On to the Wuhan Open Semifinals

From: BBC Tennis Mined: 2026-10-16 5 min read

British tennis player Sonay Kartal is on a remarkable comeback. The 24-year-old beat fifth **seed** Elina Svitolina of Ukraine 6-2, 2-6, 6-4 in the **quarterfinals** of the Wuhan Open in China.

Kartal missed more than six months of tennis with a **stress fracture** in her back. Because of that long break, her world ranking dropped to 170, even though she had reached a career-high ranking of 44 last summer. She is using a **protected ranking**, a rule that helps injured players enter tournaments, to play in Wuhan. The win over Svitolina was her sixth victory in eight matches since returning.

Kartal has been beating strong players all week. In earlier rounds, she defeated Italian 15th **seed** Jasmine Paolini and Swiss ninth **seed** Belinda Bencic. She had not lost a single set on her way to the **quarterfinals**.

Against Svitolina, Kartal broke her opponent's serve early to take the first set. Svitolina, who is ranked sixth in the world, took a medical timeout for treatment on her right arm, then came back strongly to win the second set. The third set was close until Kartal broke Svitolina's serve at 5-4 to win the match.

"It was solid **composure** from me throughout," Kartal said. "It's breaking new ground for me this week." She also thanked the crowd for the amazing atmosphere.

Kartal is only the second British player, after Johanna Konta, to reach a **semifinal** at this top level of tournament, called WTA 1000, since it began in 2009. On Saturday, she will face Je?ena Ostapenko, who won the French Open in 2017.

Word Treasure

quarterfinals -- The round of a tournament with eight players left, before the semifinals.

seed -- A ranking given to top players so they do not meet each other in early rounds.

stress fracture -- A small crack in a bone caused by repeated strain over time.

protected ranking -- A rule that lets an injured player enter tournaments using the ranking they had before getting hurt.

composure -- Staying calm and in control, especially under pressure.

semifinal -- The round with four players left; winners go on to the final.

Background you need

The Wuhan Open is a women's tennis tournament held in China as part of the WTA Tour, the main professional circuit for women.

WTA 1000 events are among the biggest tournaments on that tour, just below the four Grand Slams.

Tennis matches are played in sets, and in this format the first player to win two sets wins the match.

A break of serve happens when a player wins a game while the opponent is serving, which is often key in close sets.

Break it down

LEAD: Sonay Kartal beat fifth seed Elina Svitolina to reach the Wuhan Open semifinals
KEY EVENT: A close three-set quarterfinal, 6-2, 2-6, 6-4
+- WHO: Kartal, 24, of Britain, and Svitolina of Ukraine
+- WHERE: The Wuhan Open in China
BACKGROUND: Kartal missed more than six months with a back stress fracture and dropped to 170 in the rankings
EVIDENCE OF FORM: Six wins in eight matches since returning, including Paolini and Bencic
WHAT'S NEXT: A semifinal on Saturday against 2017 French Open champion Je?ena Ostapenko

Why it matters

Kartal's run shows how an athlete can return from a serious injury and compete with the world's best, putting her among very few British players to reach this stage.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Sonay Kartal beat in the Wuhan Open quarterfinals?

(A) Jasmine Paolini
(B) Elina Svitolina
(C) Je?ena Ostapenko
(D) Belinda Bencic

2. What was the score of the match?

(A) 6-4, 6-4
(B) 6-2, 2-6, 6-4
(C) 6-2, 6-2
(D) 7-6, 6-1

3. Why did Kartal miss more than six months of tennis?

(A) A broken wrist
(B) An illness
(C) A knee injury
(D) A stress fracture in her back

4. What was Kartal's career-high ranking?

(A) 15
(B) 170
(C) 6
(D) 44

5. Which British player reached a WTA 1000 semifinal before Kartal?

(A) Johanna Konta
(B) Jasmine Paolini
(C) Emma Raducanu
(D) Andy Murray

6. Who will Kartal face in the semifinal?

(A) Elina Svitolina
(B) Belinda Bencic
(C) Je?ena Ostapenko
(D) Johanna Konta

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: D 4: D 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):